

When consent isn't given

When someone says “no” to foreplay or sex, then their “no” means “no.” Consent has not been given. If a person wants to stop or do something else, that must be respected. If they don't consent to one act, that doesn't necessarily mean they want to end the sexual encounter, or that they have no interest in the partner. But if their partner forces them to do something they don't want to do, then that counts as sexual assault or rape.

Nobody should think saying “no” is a game or “playing hard to get.”

If someone consents once, it doesn't mean they consent for that type of foreplay or sexual activity to happen again. A person might not be comfortable another time.

Consent to one type of foreplay or sex does not mean that consent to any other type of sexual activity is given. Different people feel comfortable with different things, and enjoying one thing doesn't mean they want to do everything.

Some signals and body language can be misinterpreted and don't count as consent. It's important for a partner to check that they understand what any sounds or signs really mean.

ALERT!

No consent

Laws about the age of consent vary from country to country. A situation in which someone cannot give consent is rape. A person cannot give consent if:

- they are under a certain age (in the U.S., 16 to 18 years old).
- they are asleep or unconscious, or they fall asleep or become unconscious during sex.
- if they are threatened or forced. This might happen in an abusive relationship or in a gang environment.
- if they are high on drugs or drunk.
- if they have a medical condition or learning disability that means they are unable to understand what they are being asked to consent to.

Even when foreplay or sex is happening, either partner can change their mind and reverse their consent. If one feels awkward or uncomfortable and wants to stop, their partner should stop, and there should be no guilt or pressure.

It's wrong to assume consent, and if someone has any doubts at all, they need to ask their partner whether what they want to do is okay.

GOOD TO KNOW

Acts without consent

Sexual assault involves any unwanted intimate touching or behavior. It includes a wide spectrum of offences, from groping and harrasment to rape. It is against the law.

Sexual abuse is a crime that involves a person forcing someone to engage in sexual activity. It can include pressuring someone to reveal their genitals or to be touched sexually. Sexual abusers are often in positions of responsibility (such as a family member, teacher, or caregiver). This can make it very difficult for the person being abused to tell a trusted person about it in order to get help, but speaking out is really important so that the abuse can be stopped.

Rape is any type of sex that happens without consent. Rape is an invasive and often very violent crime. It causes the victim physical pain and emotional trauma.

Female genital mutilation (FGM) is a criminal act in which the female genitals are deliberately removed or altered. It's often carried out in unsanitary conditions without anaesthetic. Some cultures and religions believe that practicing FGM allows them to control a girl's sexuality. In fact, FGM is a type of abuse. It causes serious psychological and physical trauma (including infections and constant pain). Girls whose families originate from FGM-practicing communities are most at risk.